5.6.1 Pedagogy for Social Science

Social Science is often taught as a fixed set of facts without an understanding of how interpretations play a role in its construction. This has pushed students towards memorising facts and figures from a textbook, which is not an actual learning of Social Science. A Social Science classroom must be participatory and interactive in nature. It is only when students are allowed to immerse themselves in the process of Social Science thinking that they learn the subject better.

5.6.1.1 Pedagogical Considerations

The following pedagogical considerations should be kept in mind while planning for Social Science classes:

a. **Classroom transactions should help students engage with the method of doing Social Science** so that learners can appreciate the methods for knowledge creation in Social Science. For instance, students may be encouraged to notice patterns in the distribution of different forms of government, such as democracies, monarchies, and dictatorships across the globe and propose reasons (historical, geographical, socio-political, and economic) for the existence of those patterns.

b. **Classroom teaching should inculcate an awareness and appreciation of normative concerns.** Students should be given opportunities to reflect on various social and environmental issues in their own environment. This should lead to thinking and discussing of meaningful responses to these challenges.

c. **Multidisciplinary thinking should be encouraged and supported** to ensure that students develop a holistic and integrated understanding of concepts as they appear in society. Any event in history needs to be interpreted in the socio-political or economic contexts of its origin; any geographical phenomena should be evaluated from its impact on space and human lives and its influence on the economy and society. Similarly, any economic concept needs to be understood from its historical and socio-political contexts.

d. **A Social Science classroom should be a place for contesting ideas, debating, and arguing with empathy and care.** Students must be encouraged to share their diverse experiences and reasoning without the fear of being judged or ridiculed. The Teacher must refrain from imposing their own beliefs and biases on the students and should train students towards looking at one issue from several viewpoints. The entire pedagogy in a Social Science classroom should be an attempt to reveal newer dimensions of social reality and work towards creating self-awareness and introspection among Teachers and students.

e. **Facts and concepts in Social Science should be made relevant to the students' contexts and experiences.** Such sharing and interactions must be respectful of the cultural and socio-economic differences and multiple perspectives among students.

f. **Concepts in Social Science need to be clarified with adequate depth and rigour:** In a Social Science classroom, adequate time and attention should be given to concept formation and clarity. For example, students need to understand the processes of weathering and erosion to see their impact on topography and human civilisation; they must engage with the meaning of different types of sources of evidence to frame meaningful interpretations of historical events; and develop a comprehensive understanding of concepts of plurality and

democracy to appreciate the values enshrined in the Constitution and those stressed upon in NEP 2020. The overall classroom environment should encourage academic rigour in acquiring knowledge.

g. **The opportunity to engage with various social-political and environmental matters** through investigating and interpreting multiple sources of evidence available, such as documentaries, literature (books, local stories, travelogues), newspaper reports, and relevant films should be undertaken. Selecting materials that are relatable to students and help in developing curiosity about the discipline should be prioritised. At the same time, care should be taken to ensure that materials are taken from reliable sources of information and do not depict biases for or against a particular thought, philosophy, group, or people.

h. **Authentic tasks/performance-based tasks, such as project-based learning activities and assignments, should be incorporated** to give learners an opportunity to develop different types of capacities such as surveying, data analysis, problem solving, and collaborative skills to validate and investigate their assumptions and beliefs.

5.6.1.2 Pedagogical Strategies

To design lessons around these considerations, there are many strategies that Teachers can deploy. Illustratively:

a. **Inquiry**: Inquiry-based methods help students understand how social scientists generate knowledge. For instance, students can make and test hypotheses about factors that influence migration in their locality or region, the genesis of various settlement patterns in their region, why specific types of occupations are more prevalent in specific regions, and so on.

b. **Issues-based learning**: Issues-based learning can be a conducive tool for acquainting students with various aspects of social realities, integrating perspectives from different disciplines in investigating the causes of problems, and thinking about relevant social action. As a subject addressing normative concerns, it is also vital that students learn much of the Social Science content by engaging with real issues in their immediate/related context. For instance, students may consider the problem of drinking water shortage in their area, which may involve engaging with questions such as – What are the available sources of water? How does water consumption differ across different parts of the region/locality? Are there wastages that can be avoided? How is water being made accessible to all sections of society? Is there unequal distribution? What steps are being taken to purify water? How is it being made available to the poorer sections of society?

c. **Conversations, discussions, and debates:** Conversations are extremely vital in a Social Science classroom. These conversations should lead to focussed discussions on concepts, ideas, belief systems, and value claims. Sometimes these discussions may turn into debates in the classroom. It is important to encourage such debates, as it provides students with the opportunity to put forth their perspectives, resolve conflicts, iron out contradictory ideas, and learn from each other. However, care must be taken that such discussions and debates do not hurt the sentiments of any social group. Some common topics for discussion could be on climate change, diversity in clothing and types of food as per historical and geographical reasons and practising democratic processes in schools.

d. **Role plays and simulations**: Role plays and simulations may help students explore decision-making processes and find means for conflict resolution. For instance, role plays of the Gram Panchayat/Corporation may be used as a vehicle to explain the functioning of a democratic institution.

e. **Community service and field excursions:** Community service is yet another engaging strategy in a Social Science classroom. It not only involves concrete experiences for learning concepts from the curriculum, but also enables students to develop the desired values. Students may take up various projects to work with local government agencies to acquire first-hand experience of issues and work with people in need. Similarly, field excursions are meaningful ways of engaging with the content, e.g., nature walks, heritage walks, food walks, and visits to police stations, museums, post offices, planetariums, and government and digital archives.

f. **Reflective essays:** Students can write reflective essays on various topics related to the curriculum. These essays can also be used by Teachers to assess the extent to which students have learnt the desired concepts and skills. For instance, a reflective essay topic could be, 'How will dams transform agricultural productivity in India?', 'What are the issues and opportunities of linking rivers?', 'What sustainable agricultural strategies could a region adopt if its main river turns seasonal or dries up?', or 'Is waste management and disposal the sole responsibility of municipalities and other government agencies?

g. **Project work**: Effective Social Science teaching happens when students collaborate for a project or a specific task. These could be conducting surveys and interviews (e.g., household surveys, interviews with stakeholders of the society such as village sarpanch), drawing a map of their classroom, investigating historical sources in their region, tabulating the types of *bazaars*/marketsSuch projects should be collaboratively designed along with students with sufficient time given to collect data, analyse it, and present it in the classrooms.

h. **Some specific opportunities for projects to create models and artefacts:** Students should be given opportunities where they can apply their knowledge to create models and artefacts. These could be in the form of poster-making, collections (old coins, newspapers, stamps, types of rocks, leaves, flowers, photographs, pamphlets), models (2-dimensional or 3-dimensional, e.g., monuments, volcanoes, still scenes), videos of rallies/*haat bazaars*/ book fairs/any social events in their surroundings.

5.5.1 Principles of Content Selection

The content selection in Social Science must fulfil the Curricular Goals, account for the nature of knowledge, and should systematically address the current challenges of Social Science teaching and learning.

These considerations inform the principles below, which should be used while selecting the content:

a. **Content must be adequate to develop relevant knowledge and capacities:** The topics chosen should together be able to help achieve the relevant knowledge and capacity goals of the curriculum. At the same time, there must not be **content overload**, which has been a significant cause of ineffective Social Science teaching and learning. This balance of having appropriate amount of content is one of the key challenges in developing Social Science curricula.

b. **Content must be based on verified evidence and narratives:** A good Social Science study of any concept or event requires engaging with evidence from a range of sources, references, and consequent interpretations and narratives. The range of what is admissible evidence for Social Sciences will draw from the socio-cultural contexts of India and from multiple pieces of evidence verified rigorously from various sources; it should give a sampling of differing interpretations or narratives (if justified by verified evidence) of a single event or phenomenon. For example, good understanding of the Gandhian philosophy of non-violence should be accomplished through the readings of multiple writers, or the usefulness and limits of markets should be seen from varied perspectives.

c. **Content must be interdisciplinary in approach:** Social Science, by its very nature, is an interdisciplinary subject. The discipline-wise division of History, Geography, Political Science, and Economics, and others such as Anthropology, Philosophy, Psychology, and Sociology cannot be seen as separate areas in isolation. None of these disciplines can be

taught (or understood) without referring to another. For example, the concept of India's cultural unity in diversity cannot be taught without introducing the student to India's geographical unity in diversity, or to its shared philosophical and political concepts. Students should learn to investigate a concept from multi-dimensional and cross-disciplinary perspectives to develop an expansive view.

d. **Concepts must be built from the simple to the complex:** The content in Social Science should be organised, with simpler concepts leading to more complex ones, enabling the construction of whole meaning with building blocks. This must be done progressively, including by considering the developmental trajectory of cognitive capacities of students. For example, for teaching historical inquiry in the Middle Stage, the content would first focus on the identification and differentiation of sources of information or evidence, taking a local case study as starting point where possible. As a second step, students should interpret the evidence to draw meaning out of it. Third, where possible, they should attempt to collect and analyse evidence from multiple sources for a single event, engaging in discussions if such evidence at times appear to point to differing conclusions. And finally, where possible, they should do a comparative analysis between two or more similar events based on findings made through multiple sources. Such an exercise can be done at a basic level, to familiarise the student with the methodology in a light way.

e. **Content to progress from local to global:** As much as possible, conceptual understanding should start from the local context. For example, understanding geography is best achieved by first engaging with local terrain (streams, lowlands, uplands) in the locality, and then moving to features of the regional and national terrains. The same method is applicable to History and to other areas of Social Science.

f. **Content to include real and diverse experiences of people:** As Social Science deals with human beings and society, the study is incomplete with just theories and concepts. Without references to the real-world experiences of people, past or present, concepts do not 'come to life'. For example, the concept of an uprising against colonial rule cannot be grasped without an appreciation for the courage of the people through a few first-hand accounts or testimonies; or discrimination and efforts to address it cannot be taught without introducing the students to accounts of people who have faced it personally and those who have been helped by measures taken at various levels. Real experiential accounts also help develop values and dispositions such as empathy, sensitivity, and pride in our heritage.

g. **Content must enable development of capacities:** Social Science aims at developing decision-making and problem-solving capacities in the social context to enhance social, cultural, and environmental harmony, which involves the interpretation of facts, relying on evidence, and connecting concepts to form rational and forward-looking opinions. The content in Social Science should not merely present facts but also help develop these capacities and enable inference, analysis, and a grasp of the complex, integrated nature of human life and society while being open to other perspectives.

h. **Content must enable the development of values and dispositions:** The choice of content in Social Science and its tone of presentation should have both implicit and explicit influence on the values and dispositions of students. While the overall content must be valid and adequately representative of a range of perspectives, it should also be deeply informed by the values and dispositions that it will foster.

5.5.4 Content for Middle Stage

5.5.4.1 Summary of Approach

a. **Based on themes:** In the Middle Stage, the approach is largely based on studying 'themes'. Themes form the content of study; 'topics' are sub-parts of the themes, which may be used for practical purposes of drawing boundaries for a particular discussion/inquiry. Each Grade would have all the chosen themes.

b. **Study themes from all perspectives:** For all themes (or the topics within), study must happen from the angles and lenses of all relevant disciplines. This must cover historical, geographical, economic, and political science perspectives, as also anthropological, philosophical, psychological, sociological, cultural, and other perspectives. It is particularly important to note that:

   i. Such study should be undertaken through real-life, relatable questions – and not be classified into disciplines – the disciplinary angles must be embedded within the questions/study. The students would not be told/instructed that such and such question is from such and such discipline.

   ii. One question may embed and involve multiple disciplines.

c. **All themes should be studied at four levels in each Grade** – Local, regional, national, and global. At each level, the questions/study should be from the entire range of lenses from various disciplines.

d. **Teaching-Learning Materials** (including textbooks), pedagogy, assessment, and timetable must support this entire approach.

5.5.4.2 'Themes' for Holistic Real-life Perspective Building

To develop an interdisciplinary, holistic perspective in the Middle Stage, the study of Social Science is largely based on themes rather than disciplines.

In essence, a 'theme' is any rich and complex human phenomenon that pulls together the lenses of multiple disciplines which in turn help obtain a good understanding of the phenomenon. For example, the concepts of continuity and change, governance, or migration are the sort of ideas that are so rich in nuances and so complex in multiple ways that a reasonable understanding requires the lenses of History, Geography, Political Science, Economics, and also Philosophy, Psychology, Anthropology, and more. Such concepts can be used as 'themes' in the study of Social Science.

a. It is useful and important to note that themes are likely to have related but different characteristics across different levels of human aggregation, implying that any of these themes, when studied at the very local community level as compared to the regional, or national, or global level, will have particular and different characteristics and dynamics. For example, the political and economic aspects of governance are vastly different at the local community level and at the national level.

b. Therefore, the themes should be studied at all four levels – local, regional, national, and global – with appropriate weightage given to each level in terms of the proportion of content. Needless to say, the study of all the themes at every level will be carried out with the same integrated multidisciplinary lens.

c. Within each of the themes (and for any of its constituent matters, which may be called 'topics') study must be done using the lenses of all relevant disciplines.

The list of themes in 5.5.4.5 is useful for such an approach for studying Social Science. It needs to be noted that while this list of themes is useful and important, *it is not comprehensive*, and **curriculum developers may choose other themes as well.** The key criteria for choosing the themes are described below.

5.5.4.3 Criteria for Choosing Themes

Below is a set of criteria that can be used to choose themes. These have been used to select the themes used in the document. Other themes may be chosen by curriculum developers using these criteria.

a. The human phenomenon (or idea or concept) being chosen as a 'theme' must have the complexity that requires multiple disciplines for its study. For example, 'the flow of rivers' is not a phenomenon requiring multiple disciplines to study, as it is primarily a matter of Geography. However, 'rivers and human life' needs the perspectives of multiple disciplines and therefore could be a suitable theme within this approach.

b. The matter being chosen as a theme must be relatable in the context of the immediate environment of the student. This is not only important to develop an understanding of one's own community and locality, but it is also important pedagogically to have a relatable understanding because students learn more deeply when they can relate to things with their own lives.

c. At the same time, the matter for a theme must be such that it has a regional, national, and global dimension and relevance and is not limited to only one or two levels.

d. The overall set of themes chosen should enable the development of a syllabus and content that is sufficient to achieve the Curricular Goals in that class and of that Stage.

5.5.4.4 Themes Cutting Across Four Levels — Local, Regional, National, and Global/International

The themes should span from local to regional to country and then the world. Themes should be equally relevant and useful at all these levels.

This approach helps make the learning of Social Science observable, real-world, relevant, interesting, and connected to day-to-day occurrences for Middle Stage students, drawing them into thinking and talking about these occurrences while connecting them to the more expansive world. This would also give students a sense of their location in the world and the interconnections of matters between different levels of human aggregation.

For each of the Grades 6-8, the relative proportion of the content and of timetable space of the different levels are mentioned below. Within each level the themes should have roughly equal proportion of content. These are not tight rules, but directional guidance, and the exact proportions may vary reasonably based on other considerations.

a. Content for the local level would be 20% of the Social Science curriculum. Students will explore various facets of their locality in terms of historical context, geographical variations, and its socio-political, cultural, and economic life in an integrated manner. This will be done through collecting information/data from multiple sources, comparing data, making meaning out of it, doing analysis, and learning how social scientists build knowledge about a society based on empirical evidence. This local level should:

   i. Build familiarity with the methods relevant to Social Science and develop the related capacities.

   ii. Make the subject relatable to real life.

b. **Content for the regional level would be 30%.** The understanding and capacities developed by the local level content would be built upon to deal with content at the regional level. In this, a deeper interdisciplinary perspective would be acquired by the students, by identifying interconnections, similarities, and differences between their locality and the region. The 'region' must be chosen thoughtfully, it must of course be the region around the 'local' area; but it may be a part of the state where that locality is, or multiple states, or the entire state itself.

c. **Content for the national level would be 30%.** Students are expected to learn the national context through a similar approach, including active engagement with secondary sources. This content could include a general survey of the relevant Indian history and geography. The unity in diversity of our people and the richness of our cultural heritage, and the relevant concepts of Indian ethos, must also be introduced and studied here.

d. **Content for the global level would be 20%.** An understanding of the culture and society of other countries would help students widen their worldview. Students can build a comparative understanding of life in other countries in relation to their own. This would lead to a sense of pluralism and appreciation of various cultures around the world. A comprehensive understanding of any three countries that meet the following (or similar) criteria may be chosen:

   i. The three countries must be from different continents with different socio-cultural and civilisational histories,

   ii. One country that has geographical challenges and has gone through rapid growth after struggling through challenging times in its history (e.g., Japan, South Korea),

   iii. One country that has geographical diversity, has been a colony, and has struggled through foreign rule and internal difficulties (e.g., South Africa, Nigeria),

   iv. One country that has grown rapidly and is influential in the global economy, with multi-ethnic composition (e.g., the United States of America, Australia, Germany).

Along with other TLM, content for the local level should be in the form of workbooks, specifically designed such that, Teachers themselves should be able use it for their locality. On the other hand, the regional, national, and global level, content(s) may be covered through textbooks.

5.5.4.5 Themes Used in this Document

The themes chosen for illustration using the criteria mentioned earlier in § 5.5.4.2 are – People and Cultures, Livelihoods of People, Human-Environment Interconnectedness and Interaction, and Democracy and Governance.

A brief description for each theme, in the form of some key questions that form the rationale, is given below. Under each theme, illustrative topics are also given to help curriculum, syllabus, and content developers relate to the approach.

a. **People and Cultures:** The first step of Social Science is to study the people around us and what shapes their lives. There are multiple factors – geographical, historical, economic, cultural, psychological, and political – that enable and influence building a society and result in certain socio-cultural practices and norms in that society. These norms not only

influence individuals' lives, but also explain the functioning of group dynamics within a society. They enable us to understand the factors that influence coming together of people, or even the differences that may exist. The broader areas which this theme would cover are: What factors influence the coming together of people (trade, ideas, socio-cultural influences, people movements – whether due to pilgrimages or deliberate/forced migrations) across time and their current practices? What has changed and what has remained constant over time? What are the political, economic (education of people, clothing, livelihood), and social-cultural (language, festivals, practices) components of cultures and what are shared? What positive effect does cultural interaction have? Answers to these questions cannot be sought in isolation, and hence the other themes must also be studied in conjunction.

Illustratively, working on this theme for Grade 6, the topics may cover the following content at local and regional level:

i. Topics that can be covered at local level:

   1) What kind of changes have happened in the cultural life of the family and community in last three to four decades and what has continued? What are the reasons behind these changes and continuity? Such a topic could lead to a discussion of the role and importance of the family unit in Indian society.

   2) What kinds of differences are observed in the beliefs and practices of members of the family? What is the basis of these differences?

   3) What has been the migration pattern in the family over three to four decades? Who has migrated and where? How has it impacted the basic structure of the family?

ii. Topics that can be covered at regional level:

   4) What are the major characteristics of the culture of the people of one's own region?

   5) What were the cultural practices of the people of the region in ancient times? What has continued over this period of time?

   6) Which types of festivals are prominent in the region? What is its historical significance? What is the importance of festivals in bringing people together from different sections of society?

b. Livelihoods of People: Livelihoods remain at the centre of day-to-day activities of people and are also drivers of the cycles of interdependence in society. This in turn proceeds in defining the market dynamics, feeding the loop of demand and supply. For example, what goods and services does a society produce? Who controls the wealth and resources of a society? How and why have these changes occurred across time? What is the nature of the different markets (e.g., *Haat, Bazaar,* and *Mandi*)? Is it conceptually relevant to put Melas (fairs) as a form of market in India? How does the market influence the lives and occupations of the people? What and how are natural resources used and what is their effect on nature? What kind of governmental matters are linked to livelihood? This theme, thus, aims at enabling students to understand and interpret the dynamic relationship that the livelihoods of people have with the types of structures and institutions in the world, and their evolution. Finally, all of this must be understood in the context of the culture, aspirations of people, political environment, and more.

Working on this theme for Grade 8, the topics may cover the following content at regional and national level:

i. Topics that can be covered at regional level:

1) What do we mean by cottage, small-scale, and large-scale industries? How do geographical conditions define the possibilities of small-scale and large-scale industries in the region?

2) What is the share of small-scale and large-scale industries in economy of the region? How does it impact the standards of people's lives?

3) How has industrial development taken place in the region in the last 30-40 years and what are the major reasons behind this change? How have traditional ways of conducting business been affected by this change?

4) What is the role of the state government in addressing the unemployment and poverty in the region?

ii. Topics that can be covered at national levels:

1) How do the climatic zones affect people's lives and play a role in determining their livelihood in a particular zone?

2) Which types of agricultural practices and local industries develop in different climatic zones? How does it influence the livelihood of people?

3) What type of power sharing mechanisms and control over resources have developed over time in different regions of the country?

4) What are the impacts of globalisation on people's lives? What kinds of changes can be seen in occupations and livelihood patterns?

5) Which types of occupations have emerged over a period of time? What is its impact on society? What is the role of different sections of society in economic activities?

c. **Human-Environment Interconnectedness and Interaction:** Individuals are shaped by and are an integral part of their social and physical environment. Everything that happens in society is influenced by its surroundings and its features, from what one wears, to what one eats, to what livelihoods thrive on. It is therefore important to know: How do humans adjust to the climate and terrain in which they live? How have changes in the natural world forced people to change their behaviour and practices? What positive and negative changes have people made to their environment? How has all this changed with time? What cultural factors have played a role and how? How are collective issues resolved? These questions are some of the key components for understanding the human-environment interaction.

Working on this theme for Grade 6, the topics may cover the following content at local and regional level:

i. Topics that can be covered at local level:

1) What are the key physical features of one's locality? Is it a plain, mountainous, plateau, or coastal area? How do the physical features of a place influence the living conditions of its inhabitants?

2) Understanding the relation between crop patterns in one's locality and the physical features of that place.

3) How are land and resources distributed among the people in the locality? What are the reasons behind the disparity in the distribution of resources, if any? For example, in access to safe drinking water and school education.

4) What is a map? What are the key components of a map? What different kinds of maps are commonly made and consulted? What is the significance of a map in the lives of people? How do we make a map of one's own locality?

ii. Topics that can be covered at regional level:

1) What are the key physical features of a region? What are the climatic conditions of the region and how do they shape the lives of the people in terms of occupation and livelihood?

2) What are the natural resources found in the region?

3) What are the major crops and horticulture of the region? What are the major flora and fauna of the region and their interconnectedness with the lives and cultures of the people in the region?

4) How does the environment affect people's behaviour, such as language, food, clothing, and what is the kind of diversity found in different regions?

d. Democracy and Governance: Having understood human settlement and the multiple factors influencing the way people live, a certain kind of social and political order is required for a stable society. Governance attempts to ensure social order in society, along with taking care of the availability of resources and services for each member in the society. Democratic governance is one such form of a political structure that aims towards the inclusive and harmonious co-existence of diverse people in the society. Governance is shaped by the past experiences of the people. It is influenced by and influences social and cultural forces and trends and is deeply interconnected with economic well-being and the terrain of the place being governed. This theme focusses on understanding democracy and governance, how they have changed over time, and how this change has influenced and been influenced by technology and the economy.

Illustratively, working on this theme for Grade 8, the topics may cover the following content at national and global level:

i. Topics that can be covered at national level:

1) What is the process of government formation at union level? What are the roles and responsibilities of union government? What is its relationship with people?

2) How did India emerge as a modern democratic State? What are the values and principles that bind us together in the historical process? How does the Constitution of India address the aspirations of people and respects communities' beliefs and practices?

3) What are the types of challenges that have been faced by Indian societies across periods of time? What are the processes, policies, and mechanisms developed by the government over the period of time to deal with these challenges?

4) What types of challenges are being faced by Indian democracy in recent times? How does the government tackle these challenges to bring social and economic prosperity in society?

ii. Topics that can be covered at global level:

1) What are the key features of U.S. democracy? How is it different from Indian democracy?

2) How has democracy evolved in the U.S. from its first freedom struggle to the civil war of the 1860s?

3) What are the major issues of American society and how has economic development shaped its society?